

cially *unwell*, and it started more or less as soon as I started earning and spending my own money at eighteen. It followed me throughout university and into my first full-time job. I had my first son and got married young, and these big life milestones, coupled with a lack of understanding of what it meant to live within my means and some serious self-esteem issues, resulted in over £27,000 of credit card, overdraft and store card debt, which I finished paying off in early 2021. I chronicled this journey on my Instagram page, a warts-and-all account of what it was like to realize you had got things so wrong, and where I worked through the emotional and financial baggage that had enabled me to reach such a difficult and all-consuming situation. I asked myself why I had felt the need to spend lavishly on other people in order to feel reassured that they liked me, that I was worth something to them. Why I consistently ignored the warning signs in favour of daydreaming about a lottery win.

What I wasn't expecting on that day, when I finally reached breaking point and posted all of my credit card balances on the internet, was for it to resonate so much, with so many people. So many women, in particular. It was a strange feeling – a mixture of catharsis and sheer terror. I'd spent so long pretending that everything was fine, both on social media and to my friends and family, that this radical honesty about my failings was positively therapeutic. I wasn't ready to put my face to what seemed like such a huge sum of failings, so I remained anonymous for over a year, posting pink squares as